



REVITAL PRODUCTIONS

Technology Stack & Future-Proof Growth Plan

The complete technology stack for Revital Productions, structured as a growth plan — which tools to use at each stage from a 3-person team today to 50+ employees, now including the custom Client Onboarding & Audit Hub as the permanent internal operations layer.

INTERNAL REFERENCE DOCUMENT • CONFIDENTIAL • UPDATED AUGUST 2026

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

Built in Layers, Never Rip & Replace

This document outlines the complete technology stack for Revital Productions — an AV/production/marketing agency based in Louisiana. It is structured as a future-proof growth plan, showing exactly which tools to use at each stage of growth from a 3-person team today to 50+ employees in the future. Every tool recommendation is chosen to avoid migration pain — the goal is to add layers, never rip and replace.

Core Architecture Principle: Build in layers. Each tool owns one function. Stripe processes payments forever. QuickBooks records accounting forever. The Hub owns client data and orchestration forever. HR and project tools get added as triggers are hit — never before they're needed, never after you've outgrown them.

Revision note (August 2026): The original version of this plan (July 2026) was written before the Client Onboarding & Audit Hub existed in its current form. This revision adds the Hub as its own permanent layer, corrects how Stripe billing and e-signature actually work today, and reflects a decision made this month: FreshBooks was evaluated as an invoicing add-on and not adopted — Stripe's own invoice generation was turned on instead, so invoicing stays inside the existing integration rather than becoming a new tool.

Layer 1 — Internal Operations & Client Data: The Hub CUSTOM-BUILT

The Hub (hub.revitalproductions.com) is a custom-built, internally-owned platform — not a SaaS subscription — that every other layer in this stack plugs into. It never gets replaced by an off-the-shelf tool; it's the orchestration layer that makes the off-the-shelf tools work together. Access is gated to @revitalproductions.com Google accounts, no separate login. 82 purpose-built tool tabs share one client data model, one auth gate, and one backend.

WHAT IT OWNS	DETAIL
Client data (source of truth)	One client record shared across the whole team — contracts, audits, reporting, production workflows, sales pipeline. Nothing else in the stack is the "real" client list.
Contract & Invoice Status Tracker	Where every contract and invoice stands per client — signature status, renewal dates, payment status, recurring billing state.
E-signature (DocuSign)	Sends contracts as real DocuSign envelopes. Test mode is fully working today; live/production mode is built and ready but pending DocuSign's Go-Live review before it can send a legally-binding envelope.
Recurring billing (Stripe)	Real Stripe subscriptions and one-time charges, test and live mode side by side. See Layer 2 for the full detail — this is where it's actually built.
Sales pipeline → ClickUp sync	One-way sync: the Hub is authoritative, ClickUp is a mirror. ClickUp-side edits never flow back. (Corrects the prior version of this document, which listed ClickUp as the CRM.)
Prospect Booking	Public booking page (book.revitalproductions.com) synced to the team's real Google Calendars, Central time.
Contractor Portal	No-login, magic-link access for contractors to log hours and request time off without touching shared internal documents.
Security & automation	Per-person Idle Lock PINs, and a Monday-morning Weekly Agency Health Digest email.

Infra cost: Cloudflare Workers + Firestore, usage-based. At current team size this runs well within the low/free usage tiers of both platforms — effectively no incremental monthly cost beyond what's already listed for the tools it connects to below.

QuickBooks Online

QuickBooks is the permanent accounting foundation. It never gets replaced — only upgraded. Every CPA in Louisiana knows it, every tool in your stack connects to it, and it scales from \$0/month free today to full enterprise accounting at \$500K+ revenue.

PLAN	COST	WHEN TO USE	KEY FEATURES
Free	\$0/mo	Right now	1 bank account, 2 invoices/mo, basic P&L
Simple Start	\$38/mo	3+ clients	Unlimited invoices, Stripe sync, 1099s
Essentials	\$75/mo	5+ employees	Multi-user, bill tracking, time tracking
Plus	\$115/mo	\$500K+ revenue	Project profitability, class tracking, 5 users
Advanced	\$340/mo	\$1M+ revenue	Full analytics, payroll bundle, AI features

Note: QuickBooks raised prices in August 2026. If you sign up for a paid plan, skip the free trial to get 50% off for the first 3 months.

Stripe — Built Into the Hub

Stripe is permanent infrastructure and, as of August 2026, it's not a standalone tool you log into separately — it's built directly into the Hub's Proposal Calculator and Contract & Invoice Tracker. QuickBooks syncs from it. The Tracker's billing status reads from it via webhook.

STAGE	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS	PURPOSE
Now	Proposal Calculator generates a live Stripe Checkout link from the proposal's own computed totals (setup fee, monthly retainer, or both combined) and embeds it in the proposal PDF as a "Submit Payment" button.	Client pays directly from the proposal — no separate step
Now	That same link automatically creates or updates a matching Contract & Invoice Tracker record — one click, tracked in one place.	No manual re-entry between proposal and billing tracker
Now	Test and live mode both run permanently side by side, with a Live checkbox (off by default) and a confirmation prompt before any real charge.	Safe to rehearse a send before it's real
Now NEW AUG 2026	Real invoice documents, not just receipts. Subscription charges (recurring/combined) get a proper Stripe invoice automatically — that's inherent to how Stripe subscriptions work. One-time charges now have <code>invoice_creation</code> turned on, so they generate a real invoice too.	Client gets an actual itemized invoice, not just a payment confirmation
\$500K+	Revenue Recognition	Deferred revenue accounting
\$1M+	Stripe Connect	Marketplace or sub-account features

Transaction fee: 2.9% + \$0.30 per card transaction. ACH bank transfers are cheaper at 0.8% capped at \$5. Encourage clients to pay via ACH for large invoices to reduce fees.

Action needed: whether Stripe actually emails that invoice to the client automatically is a Stripe Dashboard setting (Settings > Billing > Invoices/Emails > "Email customers about finalized invoices"), not something the Hub's code controls. Confirm it's on for both the test and live Stripe accounts.

FreshBooks — Evaluated, Not Adopted

The July 2026 version of this plan recommended adding FreshBooks at 3+ active clients for client-facing invoicing and retainer tracking. As of August 2026, that gap is closed a different way: **Stripe's built-in invoice generation was turned on instead** (see above), so invoicing stays inside the Hub/Stripe integration rather than adding a new subscription and a new login.

What FreshBooks would still add that Stripe doesn't: automatic payment reminder/dunning emails phrased as reminders (Stripe already auto-retries failed subscription charges, but doesn't send a friendly "your invoice is due" nudge before it's overdue), and native retainer-balance tracking (deposit received, hours logged against it, balance remaining). If either of those becomes a real pain point, FreshBooks — or Stripe's own reminder settings — is worth revisiting. Not needed today.

The Most Important Layer to Plan Ahead

The tools change as you grow — but each transition is natural and well-defined. You add the next tool when you hit the trigger, never before. (Future-proofing only — nothing in this layer is built yet, and none of it is needed until the triggers below are hit.)

Phase 1 — Contractors Only (Right Now)

QuickBooks handles everything. Track contractor payments, collect W-9s, generate and e-file 1099-NEC forms at year end. No additional tool needed. The Hub's Contractor Portal handles hours-logging and time-off requests day to day, but doesn't touch payroll or tax filing — that stays in QuickBooks.

Phase 2 — First W2 Employee (Gusto)

Add Gusto the week before your first W2 hire starts. Forbes Advisor 2026 rates Gusto 4.8 stars as the best HR software for integrated payroll and HR for growing businesses up to ~500 employees. Set it up before day one so payroll is ready immediately.

PLAN	BASE COST	PER PERSON	KEY FEATURES
Simple	\$40/mo	+\$6/person	Full payroll, W2s, 1099s, basic onboarding
Plus	\$60/mo	+\$9/person	HR tools, PTO tracking, performance reviews
Premium	\$135/mo	+\$16.50/person	Dedicated support, HR advisors, compliance alerts

Gusto connects natively to QuickBooks — payroll entries sync automatically, no manual data entry.

- 1099-NEC threshold: \$600+ per contractor in 2025, increases to \$2,000 in 2026
- File by February 2 each year — no extensions
- QuickBooks e-files directly to the IRS — no third-party tool needed

Entity Structure — When to Ask About S-Corp Election

Not a tool trigger like the rest of this layer, but the same "you're already setting up payroll" moment makes it the natural time to loop in a CPA about this too. Not tax or legal advice — talk to a CPA/attorney before acting on any of this.

QUESTION	SHORT ANSWER
What actually changes	Usually not the LLC itself — electing S-corp <i>tax treatment</i> for it (IRS Form 2553). Splits income into salary (payroll tax) + distributions (not payroll tax).
When it starts paying off	General CPA rule of thumb: once net profit (not revenue) consistently runs \$60,000-\$80,000/year or higher — below that, added payroll + filing costs usually eat the savings.
2026 self-employment tax rate	15.3% on net earnings up to \$168,600 — this is what S-corp election partially shields distributions from.
Why this phase specifically	S-corp election requires paying yourself a "reasonable salary" through real payroll — Gusto is already being stood up for the first W2 hire, so it's a natural moment to evaluate both at once.
When a full C-corp conversion matters instead	Different trigger entirely — usually only relevant if raising outside investment (VCs typically want a Delaware C-corp) or issuing employee equity at scale. Not indicated by anything in this plan.
Louisiana-specific wrinkle	State-level S-corp/LLC treatment can differ from the federal picture — ask a Louisiana CPA directly rather than assuming the federal numbers above translate exactly.

Phase 3 — Growing Team (BambooHR)

Add BambooHR alongside Gusto when you have 10+ employees or hire your first dedicated People Ops or HR team member. BambooHR is the best pure HRIS for companies that already have payroll handled. Gusto stays for payroll — BambooHR handles the employee lifecycle.

WHAT BAMBOOHR ADDS	WHY IT MATTERS
Employee records & org chart	Single source of truth for all people data
Onboarding workflows	New hire is productive on Day 1 not Day 5
Performance review cycles	Structured feedback at scale
Time off tracking & approvals	Replaces spreadsheet vacation tracking
Offboarding checklists	Consistent exits, reduces compliance risk
Employee self-service portal	Staff manage own info — saves HR admin hours

Cost: ~\$6-9/person/month. Connects to Gusto for payroll sync.

Phase 4 — Scaling Fast (Rippling)

Rippling is the only HR platform that natively unifies HR, IT, and payroll in a single system. When you hit 30-50 employees, Rippling replaces both Gusto and BambooHR. Onboard a new hire, provision their laptop, enroll in benefits, and set up their email — all from one action.

- Trigger to switch: 30-50 employees or when IT device management becomes a burden
- Cost: Custom pricing, typically \$20-30/person/month
- Connects to QuickBooks/Xero for payroll accounting sync
- Supports 100+ countries if you ever hire internationally

Productive (AV / Production Specific)

Productive is the default for \$1M-\$15M agencies in 2026. For an AV/production/marketing agency it solves the specific problem of knowing which video shoots made money, which retainers are profitable, and what your true cost per hour is per team member. Posts to QuickBooks cleanly.

WHAT PRODUCTIVE TRACKS	WHY IT MATTERS FOR AV/PRODUCTION
True cost per project	Know if each video shoot was profitable before invoicing
Billable rate by role	Director vs. editor vs. PA — different rates tracked separately
Retainer utilization	See which marketing retainers are over/under delivering
Resource planning	Book crew and equipment across shoots without conflicts
Budget vs. actuals	Compare estimated vs. real cost per campaign
Client profitability	Rank clients by margin — know who to fire and who to grow

Cost: \$24-32/user/month. Add when revenue hits \$500K. Below that threshold, a Google Sheet per project covers the basics at no cost.

Note: equipment/gear management (Rentman vs. Lasso) and payroll platform choice (Gusto vs. Rippling vs. BambooHR) were separately researched this session as future-proofing, not immediate needs — Rentman and Gusto were the grounded recommendations if/when those triggers are hit. Not detailed further in this document since neither is adopted yet.

Full Stack by Stage

Today — 3 people, contractors only

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
The Hub	~\$0/mo (usage-based infra)	Client data, contracts, DocuSign (test mode), Stripe billing, booking, contractor portal
QuickBooks Free	\$0/mo	Accounting, expense tracking, basic P&L
Stripe (via the Hub)	\$0 + 2.9%	Client payments from proposals + recurring billing, test/live
ClickUp	Already active	Mirrors the Hub's sales pipeline — not the CRM itself

3+ Clients — revenue growing, active retainers

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
QuickBooks Simple Start	\$38/mo	Unlimited invoices, Stripe sync, 1099s
Stripe	Keep	Payment processing + auto-generated invoices — permanent

FreshBooks is no longer part of this stage — see Layer 3 (Stripe) for why.

First W2 Hire — first full-time employee joins

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Gusto Simple	\$40 + \$6/person	Full payroll, benefits, W2s, onboarding
QuickBooks Simple Start	Keep	Payroll syncs from Gusto automatically

Full Stack by Stage

5-10 Employees — team growing, HR needs increase

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Gusto Plus	\$60 + \$9/person	Add HR tools, PTO, performance reviews
BambooHR	~\$6-9/person	Employee records, org chart, lifecycle mgmt
QuickBooks Essentials	\$75/mo	Multi-user, bill tracking

\$500K+ Revenue — project profitability becomes critical

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Productive	\$24-32/user	Project profitability, utilization, rate cards
QuickBooks Plus	\$115/mo	Project costing, class tracking
Gusto + BambooHR	Keep	Payroll and HR — stable

30-50 Employees — IT and HR converge

TOOL	COST	PURPOSE
Rippling	~\$20-30/person	Replaces Gusto + BambooHR — HR + IT unified
QuickBooks Advanced	\$340/mo	Full analytics, payroll bundle, AI features
Productive	Keep	Project profitability — permanent
The Hub	Keep	Still the client data/operations layer — permanent

Monthly Cost by Stage

STAGE	MONTHLY COST	TOOLS ACTIVE
Today	\$0/mo	The Hub + QB Free + Stripe + ClickUp
3+ clients	~\$38/mo	+ QB Simple Start (Stripe invoicing already built in)
First hire	~\$85/mo	+ Gusto
5 employees	~\$150/mo	+ BambooHR
10 employees	~\$425/mo	+ Productive + QB upgrade
20 employees	~\$900/mo	Rippling + QB Advanced + Productive
50 employees	~\$2,500/mo	Full enterprise stack

Figures updated to remove FreshBooks (~\$17-30/mo depending on stage in the prior version); the Hub's own infra cost is usage-based and not itemized here — see Layer 1.

Louisiana Compliance Milestones

These are the legal thresholds that trigger new obligations as Revital Productions grows. Each milestone requires action — your tools should be in place before you hit each one.

MILESTONE	THRESHOLD	WHAT IT TRIGGERS	TOOL THAT HANDLES IT
1099 filing	\$600+/contractor (2025), \$2,000+ (2026)	File 1099-NEC by Feb 2	QuickBooks
Employer account	\$50K+ annual payroll	Register with Louisiana Workforce Commission	Gusto (handles registration)
Title VII	15+ employees	Anti-discrimination law applies	BambooHR (policy tracking)
COBRA	20+ employees	Must offer health continuation coverage	Gusto + benefits broker
FMLA	50+ employees	Family & Medical Leave Act applies	Rippling (FMLA tracking built in)
ACA	50+ employees	Must offer health insurance or pay penalty	Rippling + benefits broker

Immediate Action Items

Do This Week

- Confirm the Stripe Dashboard setting "Email customers about finalized invoices" is ON for both the test and live accounts (Settings > Billing > Invoices/Emails) — otherwise the new auto-generated invoices won't reach clients on their own
- Set up QuickBooks Free at quickbooks.intuit.com/online/free — takes 10 minutes
- Connect your business bank account to QuickBooks
- Connect Stripe to QuickBooks — the Stripe Connector app itself is free to install (search "Stripe" under All apps in QuickBooks), but actually syncing/reviewing the imported transactions requires upgrading off the Free plan to Simple Start (\$38/mo, promo pricing available at signup) — confirmed by hitting QuickBooks' own upgrade wall when opening App Transactions
- Log all existing clients as contacts in QuickBooks
- Get GL + E&O insurance quotes before taking on paid clients — no policy in place yet (see Business Insurance Shortlist below)

Business Insurance Shortlist

No general liability or errors & omissions policy in place yet. Start quotes with:

- **Hiscox** — built for small creative/marketing shops, fast online quotes, modular GL + E&O bundling
- **Insureon** — broker that shops the risk across carriers (Hartford, Chubb, others); good comparison quote
- **The Hartford** — scores well specifically for ad agencies on price and coverage breadth
- **Chubb (MediaGuard)** — pricier but E&O built for production/media work (music licensing, likeness rights, content claims)
- **Berxi** — media/marketing-focused, fast baseline quote to compare against the others

Since Revital does on-location shoots, also ask each for inland marine coverage (equipment) and a certificate of insurance (COI) rider — some venues/clients require a COI before allowing a shoot on their property.

Paying Contractors & Vendors

Stripe is built for collecting payments from clients, not paying out to contractors or vendors — it's not the right tool for this. QuickBooks Bill Pay would handle it in-app, but that feature requires the Essentials plan (\$75/mo), not Simple Start. Two practical options today:

- **Direct bank transfer (recommended for now)** — send ACH or wire directly from Revital's business bank account using the contractor's account/routing number. No new tool needed. Log each payment in QuickBooks as an expense against that contractor's vendor record so it's tracked toward the \$600+ threshold for 1099-NEC filing.
- **Melio** — free tool (5 free ACH transfers/month, \$0.50 each after) with 2-way sync to QuickBooks Online for vendors, bills, and payments. Its paid Core tier also automates W-9 collection and 1099 generation. Worth adopting once paying contractors regularly makes manual 1099 tracking a pain — a common workaround to avoid the Essentials upgrade just for bill pay.

Do at 3+ Clients

- Upgrade QuickBooks to Simple Start (\$38/mo) — skip free trial to get 50% off 3 months
- No separate invoicing tool needed — Stripe's built-in invoice generation (turned on August 2026) already covers client-facing invoices
- If retainer-balance tracking or automated reminder emails become a real gap later, revisit FreshBooks or Stripe's own reminder settings then — not needed now

Do Before First Hire

- Set up Gusto at gusto.com the week before your first W2 employee starts
- Complete Gusto + QuickBooks integration so payroll syncs automatically
- Set up employee handbook and onboarding checklist in BambooHR
- Open a Louisiana employer account with the Workforce Commission